



Howard County
Office of Human Trafficking Prevention
Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council
2024 Report

Stronger connections. **Stronger futures.**

WORKING TOGETHER

The Office of Human Trafficking Prevention's mandate to work against sex and labor trafficking in Howard County is supported in part through the work of the **Howard County Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council** (HTPCC), an appointed and voluntary body which held its first meeting in December 2017. The HTPCC was made permanent by county legislation, (CB 52-2019) that took effect January 2020.

The Office of Human Trafficking Prevention aligns with the values and standards of the Maryland Human Trafficking Task Force, partnering with anti-trafficking agencies and organizations which conform responsibly to best practices in the field.



Calvin Ball
County Executive

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2024 ANNUAL REPORT

HOWARD COUNTY

Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council

Department of Community Resources and Services

OVERVIEW AND BACKGROUND

In 2014, Howard County commissioned the first Howard County Human Trafficking Task Force. Task Force members concluded that there was a strong basis to recommend increased services to victims; human trafficking awareness education for everyone in our community; and additional coordination between our various partnering agencies and community-based organizations. 2017 saw the creation of the Office of Human Trafficking Prevention within the Department of Community Resources and Services (DCRS) and the implementation of an Executive Order establishing the Howard County Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council (HTPCC). The Executive Order required the Council to conduct the following activities: review and prioritize the recommendations of the Human Trafficking Task Force Report of 2014 and advise the County Executive on effective methods and organizational structure to permanently coordinate and sustain human trafficking prevention efforts in the County. The Coordination Council began meeting in mid-2017 focused on these tasks. The HTPCC was made permanent by County legislation in 2019 (CB 52-2019) and remains staffed by the DCRS Office of Human Trafficking Prevention. In late 2019, the HTPCC and DCRS issued a multi-year report to the County Executive making several recommendations regarding the HTPCC, DCRS' OHTP and future efforts against trafficking.

The HTPCC is a diverse body of Howard County residents, professionals and service providers who are charged with helping to identify the need for increased awareness, education, survivor support and collaboration, in conjunction with the OHTP coordinator. HTPCC meetings and activities to date have included six regular full-council meetings and numerous sub-committee meetings that meet on a bimonthly basis. The Council is fortunate to have many partners in addition to the ones mentioned previously. These include healthcare, homeless services and foreign-born focused entities which provide services and resources to members of the Howard County community.

A Letter from the Chair of the HTPCC

2024 was a year of transition, reorganization, growth, and success for the Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council.

The Council partnered with the Howard County Office of Constituent Services to recruit new members for both community engagement and professional appointments. As a result, four new applicants have joined, each bringing valuable expertise and perspective to the HTPCC. In addition, several members were reappointed, ensuring continued representation from all mandated entities, as well as members-at-large from the broader community and local businesses.

One of the year's major accomplishments was the re-establishment of our subcommittee structure. The four subcommittees include Legislative, Training, Outreach and Prevention, and Screening Assessment Tool. Each will focus on advancing policy at the county, state, and federal levels, strengthening training and outreach within Howard County, and developing identification tools for service providers supporting survivors of human trafficking. In addition, the reactivation of the CORE Team subcommittee created valuable space for direct service providers to collaborate on complex cases and identify gaps within existing systems.

Collectively, The Office of Human Trafficking Prevention (OHTP) and HTPCC began a partnership and working relationship with a large national support agency (TAT). Through an outstanding virtual presentation to the Council, they outlined various opportunities for future collaboration on human trafficking and labor trafficking awareness events here in Howard County and the Greater Baltimore region. We also supported efforts by OHTP in bringing a very successful Partner2Prevent event and virtual film discussion of the documentary "Shattered Dreams" during Human Trafficking Awareness and Prevention Month in January.

As we look forward, the Council is excited to focus on action-oriented and solutions-focused work and to continue to support the outstanding efforts of the Howard County Office of Human Trafficking Prevention.

Respectfully,

Chuck Chandler
2024-2025 HTPCC Chair



SUBCOMMITTEES

In 2024, the HTPCC began efforts to reestablish and strengthen its subcommittee structure to improve strategic coordination and enhance the Council's long-term impact. This included the reactivation of the CORE Team Subcommittee, which brings together key service partners to discuss case-sensitive services and active trafficking concerns; the Legislative Subcommittee, which tracks and informs local and state policy efforts; and the creation of a new subcommittee dedicated to developing a standardized Screening and Assessment Tool. This new tool is intended to support early identification of potential trafficking victims and promote consistent, best-practice service responses across partner agencies.

CORE Team Meetings

The CORE Team Subcommittee reconvened in April 2024 and met on a bi-monthly basis, totaling five meetings throughout the year. Initially established through the OVC Enhanced Collaborative Model (ECM) Grant, the purpose of the CORE Team is to bring together key direct service partners for coordinated case review, discussion of emerging trends, identification of service and system gaps, and collaborative support on active and ongoing human trafficking cases in Howard County. All members of the subcommittee have signed confidentiality agreements to ensure the secure and ethical handling of case information. Participating agencies include the Department of Community Resources and Services (DCRS), the Office of Human Trafficking Prevention (OHTP), the Howard County Police Department (HCPD), the Child Advocacy Center (CAC), HopeWorks of Howard County, and TurnAround Inc.

Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council

REPRESENTED MEMBERSHIP

The HTPCC consists of 19 to 23 members and designees.

Representative from the Director of the Department of Community Resources and Services	Jacqueline R. Scott
Representative from the Administrator of the Office of Human Rights and Equity	Yolanda Sonnier
Representative from the State's Attorney's Office.....	Rich Gibson
Representative from the Chief of Police	Chief Gregory Der
Representative from the Howard County Commission for Women	Jessica Epps
Representative from the Director of the Department of Social Services	Geneva Rieu
Health Officer or the Health Officer's designee	Ilise D. Marrazzo, MPH, RN
Representative from the Sheriff's Department.....	Dina Ward
Representative from the Howard County Public School System.....	Lauren Blake, EdD

Appointed members of the private sector shall include:

Two representatives from the faith-based community	Vinitha Nithianandam
Representative from HoCo AGAST (Howard County Advocacy Group Against Slavery and Trafficking) or similar group who providing intervention and advocacy on behalf of human trafficking victims	Sara Cochran
Representative from HopeWorks	<i>appointment pending</i>
Representative from a non-profit agency providing services to human trafficking survivors (TurnAround, Inc.)	<i>appointment pending</i>
Representative from Grassroots Crisis Intervention Center;	<i>appointment pending</i>
Representative from the Howard County General Hospital	<i>appointment pending</i>
Two representatives from the survivor community	<i>appointment pending</i>
Representative from the general public	<i>appointment pending</i>
Representative from the business community.....	Chuck Chandler



Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council ACTIVITIES, HIGHLIGHTS AND TRAININGS

Human Trafficking Awareness and Prevention Month 2024

In January 2024, the HTPCC hosted two key events for Human Trafficking Awareness and Prevention Month: the Partner2Prevent panel discussion and a virtual film discussion of the documentary “Shattered Dreams.” The panel brought together local partners to examine how human trafficking presents in Howard County, highlight collaborative efforts in survivor support, and discuss targeted prevention strategies. The film discussion centered on lived experiences of survivors featured in the documentary, prompting dialogue on lessons for community and service response.

Training and Outreach

- Throughout the year, HTPCC members expanded outreach and training efforts to reach diverse communities and professional sectors. This included targeted trainings for the AAPI community, older adults, and the beginning of a new outreach initiative to train HCPSS Student Support Staff. The Council remains committed to increasing awareness and strengthening prevention efforts across the county.
- In 2024, a new partnership was introduced between the HTPCC and TAT (formerly known as Truckers Against Trafficking). TAT provided a virtual informational presentation to HTPCC members, outlining opportunities for future collaboration, training, and community engagement. With successful partnerships already established across Maryland, TAT is eager to build new relationships in Howard County to support anti-trafficking efforts and expand their impact.
- In the fall of 2024, members of the Council conducted outreach at both the northbound and southbound Maryland Welcome Centers along I-95. At the southbound rest stop, members engaged directly with truck drivers and Welcome Center staff, distributing educational materials and confirming the display of large National Human Trafficking Hotline public service announcements in restroom areas.
- Members of the Council distributed Liberty Act cards and Know Your Rights (KYR) cards to organizations attending HTPCC meetings, as well as to educators, faith-based communities, business representatives, and community members across Howard County. Human trafficking awareness materials were also shared with immigration-focused organizations serving residents in the county, furthering community education and engagement around this issue.

HTPCC Membership

- The Council continued to prioritize membership growth and inclusion, particularly in recruiting survivor leaders. Several new members have been appointed, helping to ensure diverse perspectives and representation from key sectors across the community.

IN CONCLUSION

In 2024, the Howard County Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council (HTPCC) expanded its outreach, training, and collaborative engagement strategies to better serve historically underserved populations and strengthen its internal capacity. In partnership with the Office of Human Trafficking Prevention (OHTP), the Council delivered targeted presentations and trainings to a diverse range of audiences, including members of the Asian American and Pacific Islander (AAPI) community, older adults, and school-based professionals across Howard County. These efforts helped increase awareness of trafficking indicators and response strategies in culturally relevant and age-appropriate ways.

The Council strengthened outreach to AAPI communities through a growing partnership with the Asian Pacific American Legal Resource Center (APALRC), whose linguistic and cultural expertise supported meaningful engagement and resource dissemination. In parallel, the HTPCC began establishing connections with TAT to explore prevention strategies within industries vulnerable to labor exploitation.

Recognizing the importance of centering survivor voices, the Council prioritized relationship-building with survivor leaders and advocates. Notably, collaboration began with Restoring Ivy, a survivor-led organization providing clinical and systems-level expertise. These partnerships reflect the Council's growing commitment to trauma-informed, survivor-informed approaches to policy and outreach.

To strengthen local understanding of labor trafficking, the Council supported research efforts by Choice Research Associates, whose work provided data-driven insight into risk factors and barriers to identification across Maryland. The HTPCC, in partnership with the OHTP, also continued its collaboration with Centro de los Derechos del Migrante (CDM), utilizing their national expertise to inform outreach and education strategies for migrant and contract labor communities.

Internally, the HTPCC took active steps to reestablish several of its subcommittees, foster deeper engagement with survivor leaders, and fill remaining open appointments to ensure diverse and representative leadership within the Council.

Together, these efforts reflect the Council's ongoing dedication to fostering a coordinated, inclusive, and evidence-based approach to human trafficking prevention throughout Howard County.

Goals for 2025

These goals reflect the Council's ongoing commitment to fostering a coordinated, inclusive, and survivor-informed approach to preventing human trafficking in Howard County.

As the Howard County Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council (HTPCC) reflects on the progress made throughout 2024, it remains committed to advancing its original recommendations while setting forth new goals that will guide its work in 2025. Looking ahead, the Council will focus on the following priorities:

- **Center Survivor Leadership and Membership on the Council**
Continue to build intentional partnerships with survivors and individuals with lived experience, ensuring their voices inform outreach, community engagement, and collaborative initiatives.
- **Reinforce Subcommittee Infrastructure**
Strengthen and expand the Council's subcommittee structure to better address the diverse needs of Howard County's communities and support targeted, responsive approaches to prevention and intervention.
- **Create a Countywide Screening and Assessment Tool**
Develop and implement a standardized screening and assessment tool for direct service providers to improve the identification of potential trafficking victims and ensure consistent, best-practice responses across agencies.
- **Enhance Community Collaboration**
Identify and pursue opportunities to deepen relationships with local partners and stakeholders, with a focus on cross-sector collaboration to strengthen anti-trafficking efforts and increase public awareness.
- **Advance Awareness for Vulnerabilities to Trafficking**
Expand outreach efforts to meet the needs of populations most vulnerable to human trafficking, using best-practice, victim-centered approaches that prioritize cultural responsiveness and equity.
 - 1) Build Council Capacity: Work closely with County Administration to fill vacant Council appointments and ensure a fully representative, engaged, and effective membership body.
 - 2) Plan Events for Human Trafficking Prevention and Awareness Month for 2025: Begin work on planning a Council-led event for January of 2025.

PARTNER2PREVENT 2024



The Partner2Prevent 2024 event featured welcome remarks from County Executive Calvin Ball, representatives from community partners and a panel of experts in the fight against human trafficking. Top photo, L to R, Lisa Terry, Ashton Petta, Jackie Scott, and Cheryl Mattis from the Department of Community Resources and Services. Pictured above, Petta facilitated the panel discussion. At left, Howard County Executive, Calvin Ball (center) with staff member, Hamzah Yousef, Ashton Petta, and representatives from the Maryland Transportation Authority Police Department.

Opposite Page, top left, Amanda Rodriguez, CEO, TurnAround, Inc. addresses the room. Center photo, Mirella Beltram, Polaris, takes questions from attendees. Top right, Lt. Eric Kruhm, Howard County Police Department addresses safety concerns and how the HCPD are responding to the fight against human trafficking.

At right, attendees took home the latest updates and information from Partner2Prevent 2024.

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If you need this information in an alternate format, contact the Office of Human Trafficking Prevention at 410-313-6558 (voice/relay) or ohtp@howardcountymd.gov.